Release R1c

Gettysburg Interactive Map: User Guide

Prepared October 4, 2026 from the project's files. It describes the release as built and tested; the release has not been published.

> **Candidate draft.** This guide is generated from the project's files and is not published.

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1. About this guide

This guide describes release R1c of the Gettysburg Interactive Map, the build the project calls Tranche 0. That release has not been released: it is built and tested locally and is not deployed. The guide documents what that release does, not what is planned.

The map follows the Battle of Gettysburg, July 1–3, 1863. It places 465 regiments and 104 batteries on the field and moves them through 675 moments, with 24 written stories and a chronology of 137 events.

Since-version notes

Some behaviour is newer than the site that was live on September 30, 2026. Each such item carries a note that says when it arrived:

What the since notes mean

Note	Meaning
No note	in the site as it was served on 2026-09-30
Since R1a	added in release R1a (keyboard, crash and layout fixes on the existing page)
Since R1b	added in release R1b (phone layout, keyboard and screen reader support)
Since R1c	added in release R1c (dates, day jumps, share links, corrected Help wording)

How this guide was checked

- Every key and gesture in this guide is compared, by a script, with the Help dialog that release R1c shows, with the key handler of the app, with the site menu and with the heading of each page. A difference stops the build of this guide.
- Everything in this guide was checked against the release's text, key handler and tests. Release R1c has been run only in Chrome on a desktop computer (touch was emulated). Safari, Firefox, Samsung Internet and real phones have not been tested.

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2. Start here

Open the map in a web browser. On a computer you see the whole toolbar and the playback bar. On a phone or a touch tablet up to 834 pixels wide, and on a phone held sideways, you see the phone layout instead. Since R1b The layout is chosen automatically. Add ?layout=desktop or ?layout=mobile to the address to force one.

1. **Play.** Press Space on a computer, or the play button on a phone. The map plays through time and the units move.
2. **Pause.** Press Space again, or the play button.
3. **Step.** Press the Right arrow to move forward one moment and the Left arrow to move back one. On a phone use the two step buttons.
4. **Jump to a day.** Press 1, 2 or 3 to go to the start of July 1, 2 or 3. On a phone use the three day buttons.
5. **Look at a unit.** Click it, or tap it, to see its details.

The Help panel lists the keys. Press ? on a computer, or open Help from the toolbar or the Tools sheet.

A moment is not a fixed length of time. The map has 675 moments. They are steps through the story, and the time between two moments is not the same everywhere. The section About the clock explains what that means for the times you see.

3. Move through time

These keys work on a computer, also after you click or drag on the map: a press on the map hands keyboard focus back to the page. A key that is typed into a text field goes to the field instead.

Keys for time

Key	What it does	Since
`Space`	Starts or stops the playback. With a button focused, Space presses that button instead.	Original site
`Right arrow`	Moves forward by one moment.	Original site
`Left arrow`	Moves back by one moment.	Original site
`Shift + Right arrow`	Moves forward by 12 moments. The Help panel calls this one hour; the time between moments varies, so it is not one hour of battle time everywhere (see About the clock).	Original site
`Shift + Left arrow`	Moves back by 12 moments (the Help panel calls this one hour).	Original site
`1`	Jumps to the first moment of July 1 (dawn) and pauses.	Original site
`2`	Jumps to the first moment of July 2 and loads that day's positions. Since R1c The day's positions are loaded before the jump lands. On earlier builds the map can show empty or stale positions after a day jump.	Original site
`3`	Jumps to the first moment of July 3 and loads that day's positions. Since R1c The day's positions are loaded before the jump lands.	Original site

Keys for speed

Key	What it does	Since
`Minus`	Halves the playback speed, down to 0.25 times.	Original site
`Plus or Equals`	Doubles the playback speed, up to 16 times.	Original site
`0`	Returns the playback speed to 1 times. The speed label reads 1x (base speed). Since R1c The label no longer describes a clock rate: the playback is a time-lapse.	Original site

The speed starts at 1 times. The speed label reads 1x (base speed) Since R1c; it no longer describes the speed as a clock rate, because the playback is a time-lapse.

On a phone

Controls of the phone layout

Control	What it does	Since
Play button	The play button starts or stops the playback.	R1b
Step buttons	The two arrow buttons step back or forward by one moment.	R1b
Timeline	Drag the bar to move through July 1 to 3.	R1b
Speed button	The speed button changes the playback speed.	R1b
July 1, 2, 3	The three day buttons jump to the start of July 1, 2 or 3.	R1b

12 moments are not always one hour. The Help panel calls the Shift and arrow keys one hour. They move 12 moments. Because the moments are not evenly spaced in time, that is not one hour of battle time everywhere.

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4. Explore the map

Move and select

Mouse and keys for the map

Key	What it does	Since
`Scroll`	Scroll the wheel over the map to zoom in or out.	Original site
`Drag`	Press and drag on the map to move it. A press on the map hands keyboard focus back to the page, so the time keys keep working afterwards. Since R1a A click, a drag or a unit selection no longer leaves keyboard focus on the map, so the arrow keys step through time as this guide says.	Original site
`Tab to the map`	Press Tab until the map has focus. The arrow keys then pan the map instead of stepping through time, plus and minus zoom it, and Shift with the arrow keys rotates and tilts it. Esc hands the keys back to the page.	R1a (Help row R1c)
`Click a unit`	Click a unit to select it and pin its details. From Search, a unit can also be chosen with the keyboard. Since R1b A unit can be selected from Search by keyboard: type in the field, press Down arrow to move into the list and Enter to choose a unit; focus then moves to the unit's details.	Original site

Key	What it does	Since
Esc	Closes the open panel or card and clears the selected unit. With several things open, Esc closes the topmost one first: the event card, then the story card, then the guided tour. Since R1a Esc also clears the pinned unit and closes Map Layers and the Distance tool; it closes the story card, event card and tour one at a time.	Original site

If you use only the keyboard, press Tab until the map has focus. The arrow keys then pan the map instead of stepping through time, plus and minus zoom, and Shift with an arrow rotates and tilts. Esc gives the keys back. Since R1a

Panels

Keys that open panels

Key	What it does	Since
F	Opens or closes the filter panel.	Original site
S	Opens or closes the unit search panel.	Original site
B	Opens or closes the bookmarks panel.	Original site
L	Shows or hides the legend.	Original site
M	Shows or hides the minimap.	Original site
?	Shows or hides the Help panel. It lists these keys.	Original site

Removed. The heatmap key was removed in release R1a. Nothing in the map read it.

The toolbar on a computer

The toolbar buttons, in order, are named below as they read in release R1c. This guide describes the ones whose behaviour the Help text, the release notes or a test establishes; the others are named and not described.

Toolbar buttons

Button	What it does
Search	Opens unit search (key S).
Filter	Opens the filter panel (key F).
Unit Roster	Not described in this guide.
Legend	Shows the legend (key L).
Monuments	Not described in this guide.
Soldier's Eye View (Street View)	Opens a list of eight viewpoints. Each opens in Google Street View in Google Maps (since R1c the label says so).

Button	What it does
Follow Your Ancestor	Opens a panel for following one regiment through the battle. Since R1c it loads all three days before it draws.
Distance Tool	Not described in this guide.
Map Layers	Not described in this guide.
Locations	Not described in this guide.
Find Unit / Location	Not described in this guide.
Bookmarks	Opens bookmarks (key B).
Help	Opens the Help panel (key ?). Since R1b it is a dialog that keeps Tab inside it and closes with Esc.

On a phone

Other controls of the phone layout

Control	What it does	Since
Drag	Drag one finger on the map to move it.	R1b
Pinch	Pinch with two fingers to zoom in or out.	R1b
Tap a unit	Tap a unit to see its details.	R1b
Tools	The Tools button opens a sheet with search, filter, roster, legend, bookmarks and the extra pages.	R1b
Desktop View	Switches to the desktop layout.	R1b

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5. More to Explore

The menu that lists these pages is called Extra Features on screen in release R1c; the style guide settles on More to Explore. On a computer the button is at the top right of the map. On a phone the pages are in the Tools sheet. Each page has a link back to the map.

There are 19 pages in the menu in release R1c.

Explore

Pages in the group Explore

Page	What it does
Search Everything	Find a regiment, battery, story or battlefield location by name.
Compare Moments	Show the unit positions at two different moments, side by side.

Page	What it does
Camera Modes	Director Mode moves the camera to where the most units are engaged. Follow Cam stays with one regiment.
High Ground (on screen: What They Could See)	Pick a vantage point and see how high it stands. The page ranks the height of 30 places on the field. It is not a line-of-sight map: trees, buildings, fences and gun smoke often decided what a soldier could see.
What-If Sandbox	Move units and change their status at a chosen moment to explore a hypothetical. It is not history. Nothing is saved, and reloading the page resets it.

Learn

Pages in the group Learn

Page	What it does
Ask the Historian	Ask about a regiment, a commander, a place or a moment. Answers come only from this site's own records. It is a search of those records, not an AI.
Documentary Mode	Read all 24 stories in order, each with its full text and a link to its place on the map.
Turning Points	Nine decisions where the battle might have gone differently, as historians have argued them.
For Students	A short guide to the battle for students and classrooms, by day.
Aftermath	What happened to the two armies, the town and the ground after July 3. It is an overview drawn from published histories, not built from unit-by-unit records.

Data and Records

Pages in the group Data and Records

Page	What it does
Regimental Biography	Pick a regiment or battery and follow its three days as one story: commander, casualties and recorded positions.
Find Your Ancestor	Search regiments by state or by a commander's surname. The site lists regiments, not individual soldiers; to find a soldier by name use the National Park Service's Soldiers and Sailors System.
Casualty Dashboard	Corps-by-corps strength across the three days. The curves are modelled from each corps' recorded engagement periods: they show when losses concentrated, not observed strength at each moment.
Regiment Fact Sheets (on screen: Battle Reports)	Make a one-page reference sheet for a regiment, to print or save as a PDF from the browser's print dialog.

Experience It

Pages in the group Experience It

Page	What it does
Immersive Mode	Plays a sound made in your browser that follows how many units are engaged at each moment. You turn the sound on yourself.
The Living Ledger	A running total of casualties across the three days, built from the same data as the Casualty Dashboard.
The Ground Remembers	Accumulates the recorded unit positions into one map, so places where units were positioned often stand out.

Share

Pages in the group Share

Page	What it does
Watch Together	Build a guided tour with your own stops and notes and share it as a file. Live Sync connects two browsers through a public connection service and can be unavailable; exporting and importing a tour always works.
Export a Video (on screen: Cinematic Export)	Record a video of the camera flying across a stretch of the battle. It is made in your browser and nothing is uploaded.

Battlefield AR. Needs a phone with a camera, GPS and compass. It is in beta and is not listed in the menu in this release; the page is still reachable by its address. Removed from the menu in R1a (tools/to/patches/PG-core.json PGC-nav-hide-ar).

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6. Share a place and time

The address of the map can carry a moment, a unit and a view, so that a link opens exactly there. Copy the address from the browser, or use the Copy link button where you see one.

What an address can say

Parameter	What it does	Since
`tick` or `t`	A moment number from 1 to 675. Wins over `day`.	R1c
`day`	1, 2 or 3: the first moment of that day (moments 1, 226 and 451). Used only when no valid `tick` is given.	R1c
`unit` or `u`	A unit id. The unit is selected and its details pinned.	R1c
`vignette` or `v`	A story id. The map moves to that story's moment. Used only when no valid `tick` or `day` is given.	R1c
`ancestor`	A regiment id. Opens the panel for following one regiment.	R1c

Parameter	What it does	Since
`z`	Map zoom. Values are kept between 11 and 18.	R1c
`ll`	Map centre as latitude,longitude, or the two parameters lat and lng. Accepted only inside the battlefield (latitude 39.7 to 39.93, longitude -77.38 to -77.1).	R1c
`layout`	mobile or desktop: forces that layout instead of the automatic choice (phones and touch tablets up to 834 px wide, and landscape phones, get the phone layout).	R1b

Read by the app when it loads. The parameters `tick`, `day`, `unit`, `vignette`, `ancestor`, `z` and `ll` arrived in release R1c; `layout` arrived in release R1b. Every value is validated; anything invalid is ignored and the map opens at its defaults.

Examples (add them to the address of the map)

Ending	Result
`?day=2`	Opens at the start of July 2.
`?tick=538`	Opens at moment 538.
`?unit=U-1MN&tick=538`	Opens at moment 538 with the 1st Minnesota Volunteer Infantry selected.
`?vignette=V-017`	Opens at the moment of the story The Cannonade.

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7. About the clock

The map plays as a time-lapse. It covers quiet stretches faster and the fighting more slowly, so one moment is not a fixed number of minutes.

- The map has 675 moments. The data files declare that each moment is five minutes; an audit measured that declaration as wrong.
- The clock the project proposes rests on 33 time anchors. All 33 are unreviewed: no historian has checked them yet.
- Release R1c changes only the date. Times can be hours off in places. Use the order of events, and the text of a story, rather than the clock.
- Times are approximate. Sources disagree by half an hour or more, and the map plays as a time-lapse.

There were no standard time zones in 1863. The proposed clock uses local mean time at Gettysburg.

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8. Keyboard reference

Every key of release R1c on one page. The Help panel shows the same keys.

Keys on a computer

Key	What it does	Since
`Space`	Play or pause	Original site
`Right arrow`	Next moment	Original site
`Left arrow`	Previous moment	Original site
`Shift + Right arrow`	Forward 12 moments	Original site
`Shift + Left arrow`	Back 12 moments	Original site
`1`	Jump to July 1	Original site
`2`	Jump to July 2	Original site
`3`	Jump to July 3	Original site
`Minus`	Slower	Original site
`Plus or Equals`	Faster	Original site
`0`	Normal speed	Original site
`Scroll`	Zoom	Original site
`Drag`	Pan	Original site
`Tab to the map`	Move the map from the keyboard	R1a
`Click a unit`	Select a unit	Original site
`Esc`	Close or deselect	Original site
`F`	Filter panel	Original site
`S`	Unit search	Original site
`B`	Bookmarks	Original site
`L`	Legend	Original site
`M`	Minimap	Original site
`?`	Help	Original site

Controls on a phone

Control	What it does	Since
Drag	Pan	R1b
Pinch	Zoom	R1b
Tap a unit	Select a unit	R1b
Play button	Play or pause	R1b

Control	What it does	Since
Step buttons	Step	R1b
Timeline	Timeline	R1b
Speed button	Speed	R1b
July 1, 2, 3	Jump to a day	R1b
Tools	Tools	R1b
Desktop View	Desktop layout	R1b

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9. Known differences and limits

These are the places where release R1c and its own text disagree, or where something is missing. They are listed so that you are not surprised.

- The Help panel and some pages still say tick and five minutes, and call 12 moments one hour. Moments are not five minutes apart everywhere; read the moment as a place in the story, not a fixed length of time.
- Clock labels can be hours off in places. Release R1c changes only the date (July 1, 2 and 3 instead of dates up to July 9); the clock itself is waiting on a decision about the time model.
- The Monuments button is in the toolbar, but it shows nothing in this release. The star layer that appeared when it was pressed was removed from the site in production, and restoring it properly is on the owner's list.
- The heatmap key and the in-map sound switch were removed in release R1a. Immersive Mode is the page that plays sound.
- Some labels on screen use older names, for example the menu is called Extra Features and one page is called Battle Reports. This guide uses the names the style guide settles on and gives the on-screen label beside the first mention.
- Ask the Historian searches this site's records. The count shown on its page is computed from the loaded files.
- Everything in this guide was checked against the release's text, key handler and tests. Release R1c has been run only in Chrome on a desktop computer (touch was emulated). Safari, Firefox, Samsung Internet and real phones have not been tested.

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10. Using the map with a keyboard or a screen reader

- Release R1b added a skip link, landmarks, labelled controls, a timeline that works as a slider with its value in words, and dialogs that keep keyboard focus. These are a bridge, not a claim of conformance to the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines.
- To choose a unit by keyboard, open Search with S, type in the field, press Down arrow to move into the list and Enter to choose a unit. Focus then moves to the unit's details.

- Esc closes the topmost panel or card first.
- Space pauses the playback.

The Accessibility Statement lists what was tested, the results and the known gaps, including that no screen reader test is on record.

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11. Get help or report a mistake

The Corrections page explains how to report a mistake in the history or the data. The Contact page has the addresses for questions, accessibility barriers and security reports. Both are written as candidate pages and are not published yet.

The site itself is at gettysburginteractivemap.com. Its Privacy and Terms pages describe what the site collects and how it may be used.

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12. Glossary

Terms this guide uses

Term	Meaning
moment	a point in the battle you can view on the map
story	one of the written accounts of a key event
event	one entry of the chronology shown on event cards
turning point	a decision historians still debate
regiment, battery	an infantry or cavalry regiment; an artillery battery
order of battle	the list of every unit on the field and how it is organised
casualties	men killed, wounded, and captured or missing, added together
reconstruction	a position or time worked out from sources, not recorded directly
time-lapse	the playback: faster through quiet hours, slower during the fighting